Arclight 0.3 - Static

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/86762521.

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Mature

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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by ThiaKerrigan

Summary

While stuck in a co-opted maintenance closet that precisely two people know about, a crime-fighting jock and a telepathic cat/girl get to know each other in the least casual way imaginable.

She woke to the tapping of a phone screen, and the absence of a cat on her abdomen, and covers she hadn't pulled up to her chin. The bulb was off and there was a different light now, blue and low, coming from somewhere beside her.

The thread was still there, quieter, the affect on the other end a thin focused impression of *working*.

Adora turned onto her side.

Catra was sitting cross-legged on the floor by the mattress, back against the wall, in Adora's pyjama shirt and Adora's plaid shorts again, the band shirt sliding off one shoulder and the shorts riding up one thigh in a way that Adora, in the cathedral hush of the post-sleep half-second, didn't have the defences for.

Catra looked up, and threw her a lazy smirk. "I knew me wearing your clothes had *some* effect on you, but god, you're so fucking gay." The thread turned smug.

Adora very literally covered her face with her hands.

I'm sorry, she sent down the thread.

"Calm down, hero. There's no such thing as thoughtcrime."

"Even though you can hear it?" Adora managed, her voice muffled by the blanket and her hands.

"Especially then," Catra said. "Impulses don't mean jack compared to actions, yeah? Every telepath learns that, sooner or later— or they lose their minds."

"That sounds… I'd never thought about that."

"Mhm."

"…can I see?"

The frankness of the question seemed to catch Catra unawares. Her head turned quickly, she met Adora's gaze with her own face a little slack, an expression undecided and uncommitted. A sliver of curiosity. More than a hint of anger. *Do you know what you're asking?*

"I don't. But that's the point."

What?

"She-Ra comes from my imagination. The better I can use it, the stronger she is. Even this little link you've given me was completely outside my way of imagining the world. So, if we have time while we're here, I'd really like to see what telepaths see."

You really do not know what the fuck you're asking for. Indignation, strong. This was escalating so much faster than it should. Why didn't that feel like a problem?

So show me.

Catra growled, surged forward, pushed Adora down hard. *Wide-field telepathy breaks people. Permanently. Last chance to back down, tourist.* Her eyes bored furious into Adora's.

Adora set aside the wave of *need* with superhuman force— she knew full well Catra had felt it down the thread— but right now it was incidental, and she knew that Catra understood that too.

"I said, show me."

The woman with the blue and gold eyes holding her down snarled, her lip twisted up and the thread laced with contempt, and Adora finally realised where she'd seen that pattern and that fury before, and she nodded, and then Catra's hand was against the side of her face and her thoughts were stretching, growing, a hall of mirrors yawing out in every direction, clusters of fireflies where-ever she thought, threads like Catra's but different filling the space with constellations of glittering wire.

And they were noisy, and they were all coming at once, and it felt like getting shot in the head.

A few years back, Catra's voice growled beneath all other sound. *A mother brought her son to the Railroad. He was one of the strongest telepaths we'd ever encountered, and he could barely control it. Wide-field. Full receipt of all layers of thought from all conscious minds within a seven-mile radius— more if he was afraid. This is what he experienced, twenty-four seven. Mute on a good day, catatonic on a bad one.*

I sat with him for the best part of a week. Disentangled his powers as best as I could.

Everything went dark. And then, dark red neuronal sheet lighting through cloudbanks. *Layer one. Survival instincts.* There was chaos and order— some of the red was without pattern, but some of it repeated. *The faster ones are animals or children, the slower ones are adults. Every repetition is someone mortally afraid, or currently dying.*

There were hundreds.

Layer two. The red-streaked cloudbank disappeared, replaced by a boundless volume of lights of different colours. Blurred in different patterns— some as points, some as stars, some as the sorts of geometrics you saw in really artsy student films. *Emotional state.* Different clusters flared and subsided as Catra's voice rumbled. *Grief. Joy. Rage. Love. Fear.*

They too faded.

Layer three. The raw sensorium. An instant, overwhelming, overbearing, paralysing wall of noise and image and sensation. The tastes of fries and kimchi and burger and fish and salad and curry and cabbage and a million other things. The sense of a thousand different handshakes, and a thousand hands in other places. A million different conversations (a thousand different screams). So much visual data that it should have been a sheet of

pure white but instead it was every person in the city from the viewpoint of every *other* person in the city and the kaleidoscope got deeper and more fractalline the longer she looked.

Layer four. Active memory. Adora finally felt her body hauling in breath between ragged sobs as she watched. There were sweet memories here. Kind ones. But they were studded with far greater frequency than she wanted to believe with dark, repeating things that pulsed like red lightning.

Layer five. Narration. Adora's body shuddered outside as she listened in here. A sales clerk wondering if her date was going to show tomorrow. A commuter flirting with the thought of suicide. A teacher dreading the next day's class enough that his thoughts *felt* drunk. A thousand voices murmuring in sync about Prime's Light and the Talon Sun. A young man loading his father's rifle and deciding who to kill first.

All at once. All the time. Adora lost track of her body again as the entire cacophony reasserted itself for a brief, agonising moment, and then, finally, a slow descent into static.

She floated in the static for a little while. She imagined that some sci-fi tv doctor would call it 'pins and needles for your whole identity', or maybe she didn't need the tv doctor proxy to imagine what it was called because she was *feeling* it.

Parts of her started to ache. Abdomen tense and aching. Blood fizzing in her veins from hyperventilation. Eyes brimming with tears. Throat hoarse and grating.

"You still alive in there, Gray?"

Adora's voice came out gravel. "...yeah, just about. Jesus, you weren't kidding, huh?"

"I really wasn't—"

The thread *drooped*.

Catra swore, low and bitten-off. There was the sound of a cap being unscrewed.

I'm sorry, came down the thread, rapid and stumbling. *Fuck. I'm sorry. I shouldn't ha—*

You warned me. Adora pushed it back clear and deliberate. *Three times. I told you to do it. I wanted to know.*

"Drink," Catra said, and something cold arrived against Adora's hand. "Burned out a lot of neurochemicals just now. Probably going to pass out. This is for the hangover."

She drank, and the cold water helped, and her eyes wobbled back into focus.

She bundled up the thoughts. She had known that the knowledge would be worth the pain, she had known she was intruding on something, she had known that she didn't belong *but* that she had known Catra would show her the truth anyway.

She sent them down the thread, made herself look into Catra's eyes to do so.

Something vast and exhausted echoed back to her. Catra smiled weak, then tried to stand.

"Stay," Adora murmured. "Sleep."

Adora pulled her close as she went, got her arms around her, felt her breathing slow. Got two more breaths of her own before the debt landed and the ceiling came apart at the seams and it all boiled back to static.

She surfaced to warmth, with the thread turning over slowly in her chest, giving her only presence and the impression of dreaming.

The green-on-black phone was on the floor beside the mattress, screen still lit. Catra was tucked between her and the wall, face turned in to her neck, one hand loose on her abdomen.

Adora looked at the phone.

Catra's messages were barely legible. Short bursts, some words abbreviated past parsing, one string of letters that might have been a word or might not. But the shape of them was clear enough. The response from the other end read:

called in Quayside favour. clumsy house burglary staged. all munitions taken. men's mental health charity leaflet added 2 mailbox. why were u scanning? r u ok?

Adora lay still and breathed. Outreach. She hadn't thought about that.

The thread brightened slowly, in fits and starts, like a neon tube with a bad starter. Catra came back some time before she moved.

When she did move, she moved like the room couldn't be trusted. Pushed herself up on one arm. Examined her own hand with some scepticism.

"Postdrome," she said. Her voice came out scraped. "Like with migraines."

"Okay," Adora said.

Catra stayed propped on one arm, clearly doing inventory. "The read runs seven miles. I was never able to get it smaller." She flexed her fingers. "So it's always all five layers, all seven miles, nothing I can dial. Interesting that I could filter it for you, though. Might be something there. Anyway. I don't use it much... well, because of this."

A beat.

"I'm going to have to do meth about it." She looked up. Mismatched eyes, still a little unsteady. "Need you not to judge me for that."

She thought of *medication*, and the particular way Catra had said it.

"Of course I won't," Adora said, and knew that the thread was corroborating her.

Something settled in Catra's face. She reached past her, picked the phone up off the concrete, and her thumb started moving.

"You said there's no such thing as thoughtcrime."

"There isn't." Catra still didn't look up. "He can think whatever he likes. He just gets to think it in a house with no rifle in it. Impulses and actions, yeah? We don't police the first. We're allowed to stand between the first and the second."

Adora propped herself up on her elbow. The thread thinned and brightened as Catra's attention flicked, briefly, toward her, and then dulled again as it went back to the screen.

"I can still feel you," she said, then pursed her lips at the rill of amusement that arrived alongside Catra's smirk.

"Phrasing," Catra drawled.

"How does it— I mean, I get it, you said affect and intent, but…"

"Cliff notes." Catra still didn't look up. Her thumb kept moving. "The kid that gave me the mindscape couldn't live with it in his own head any more. I have a few other scraps from a few other people too. Gifts, or things they didn't want any more and I found too useful to pass along. Little bit of card-counting, little bit of telekinesis. The cat shapechange. And this thread. We're at about thirty per-cent power now— much more and you start sharing a lot more stuff you don't mean to. The guy who handed this over couldn't wait to be done with it." She paused. "Don't worry. I'll pull it back when we're both clear."

"…I don't mind it," Adora said, and realised she was being sincere.

The tapping paused. The thread did something complicated and small— a flicker of warmth, smoothed flat almost before it registered, the way Adora was beginning to recognise as one of Catra's tells. The tapping resumed.

"Noted."

Adora sat the rest of the way up. The blanket pooled in her lap. She could feel her hair tangling and matting against the concrete wall. She didn't care.

"What are you doing?"

"Asking the question I should have asked an hour ago." Catra's thumbs stilled. "The truck wasn't ours. Or it *was* ours, and it got compromised. Either way, I need to know."

"Who're you talking to?"

"DT. They run… well, most of the Railroad at this point. Immune to telepathy, hell of an asset in the right place. If anyone knows what happened to our pickup, it's them."

The thread went quiet for a long stretch. Adora pulled her knees up and watched Catra's face in the green light. The thread had gone just a little too quiet.

"Fuck," Catra said softly.

"What?"

Catra held up a finger. Kept reading. Tapped a reply, short. Read again.

"*Fuck*," she said again, with feeling, and set the phone down face-up on the concrete.

"Catra?"

"Lonnie."

"Who's Lonnie?"

"The driver. She's run six pickups for me, she's *solid*, she…" Catra rubbed the heel of her hand against her eye, hard. "They got to her sometime in the last twelve hours. DT didn't know until she missed a check-in. Then about forty minutes ago Lonnie managed to get a burst out— three words, the duress code, and a name. Her brother's name. DT thinks Prime's got him."

Ice and acid washed through Adora's whole body, and Catra's eyes widened slightly.

"So he forced her to set the trap."

"Yeah. But she folded the wing mirror and put the antenna up. Which is how I knew. Just enough warning to buy us the chase without looking like she'd sabotaged the pickup. Which means she bought herself a window. Exactly the right play. DT's reorganising around losing her— rerouting two other assets tonight, burning a safehouse, the works— but they're doing it *slow*. Slow enough that Lonnie still looks useful. Slow enough that the brother stays breathing while they decide what she's worth."

"Jesus."

"Yeah."

"That's— that's a lot of moving parts to hold in your head at once."

"DT's good at it. It's why they're in charge." Catra picked the phone back up. Tapped something short. Set it down again. "We're stuck here till they get a new line out and confirm that Prime's given up the search. Could be six hours. Could be twenty."

"Okay."

"Okay?"

"Part of me— most of me?— wants to go find Prime and… fuck, I think I could kill him right now."

"I got that impression, yeah." The thread gave her some kind of affectionate sarcasm that she wasn't entirely sure what to do with.

"But I'm still green. I know that. I'm strong, but I'm green. If I went for him now, I'd be dead or brainwashed by sunrise. So yeah. I'm not going anywhere. How can I help? What can I do with my hands?"

I can think of something shot through the thread, and Adora blushed, and Catra scowled. "Bloody liability," she said.

Subconscious power, you said? Good to know… Adora smirked, and ducked with a laugh as Catra sent her the impressively clear mental image of whacking her with a rolled-up newspaper.

Catra gave her a softer smirk than usual, and went back to her misshapen phone.

Adora crawled to the end of the mattress, where half a shrink-wrapped twelve-pack of water bottles sat. *Can I have one of these?*

Sure. Pass me one too?

She offered Catra a protein bar from her own bag as well— Catra took the apple and cinnamon, which suited Adora fine.

She went through her bags again, checking everything that might have been damaged in the chase. The tattoo kit's foam had protected the contents. Papers and idents were all rumpled but okay.

She straightened out the photograph of Adam.

Her name was Lonnie, you said?

Catra looked at her for a long moment.

You are filling my head with loud and sad right now. You wanna tell me who that is?

Adora opened her mouth. Closed it. Opened it.

"My brother. Mom and Dad were so proud when he sparked. They took him to the board, and the board offered us scholarships— the kind that change your life, you know? But when he was at college, he… changed. We couldn't prove anything, but every time he called home he was talking more and more like an army recruitment campaign. He signed up straight out of college. Standard training, then special forces. They told us he was reassigned and then they stopped telling us anything." She heard her voice doing the thing it did when she was about to lose hold of it, and she clamped down. *By the time I was old enough to ask the right questions, the people who would've had answers were all dead or missing.*

So that's why you tweaked out when I told you about Lonnie's brother.

"Yeah. I just…" *Nobody else should ever have to feel that way, you know?*

A shaky breath puffed out of Adora as Catra's hand took the photograph from her, set it carefully to one side. Then there was a

warm rough hand on her jaw, a thumb on her cheek.

Railroad looks after its own, Catra's eyes bored into hers as she guided Adora to lay back down. *We'll find him, and get him safe.*

"Okay," Adora croaked out, at the same time as *you're so fucking pretty* escaped down the thread.

Catra smirked, and pulled the blanket up. *Later, Romeo. It's 4am. Back to sleep.*

A burst of confidence from herself and a sensation of want from the thread, and Adora folded her arm over Catra, tucking her in to her chest.

"When this is all over, can I take you to dinner?" She let herself murmur into Catra's hair.

A burst of a chuckle against her chest. *Definitely.*

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